hands-on in the nets, but his job is to make us all feel ten feet tall and bulletproof when we walk on to the field. I already feel it just by taking the first practice session.

Baz and Ben are very aligned. They want us to entertain. They want us to be a team that people are excited to come and watch. The style of cricket is simple – find ways of putting the opposition under pressure and, if ever in doubt, take the positive option. There are range-hitting drills and very little scrutinised training. Everyone is left to prepare according to their own needs. They both make clear in their understated and unfussy ways that the mentality of this team is going to be different. We will not be playing for draws and the most aggressive or exciting option is always the best one.

There are no stats or analytics, which create a ceiling for how well players play – there is just a freedom to show the world what you can do. Unusual, instinctive fields will be set, bowlers will be at all times encouraged to take wickets, even if it goes for runs. It goes against much of the received wisdom I have played Test cricket under and for a group of players largely unchanged from the challenging few years we have just had, something is unlocked for everyone.

Baz's manner is the same regardless of the game's situation. Generally smiling and positive, he has a way of making players feel relaxed. Joe Root gets out reverse-scooping and Baz says to him, 'Good ball that, mate.' He follows this up with, 'Next time, hit it for six,' and his humour immediately puts everyone at ease. It's a mindset so far removed from the England team I joined almost 20 years ago that it makes the game seem almost unrecognisable.

Stokes's role is as key as Baz's. Right from the beginning, he leads from the front. He projects how the team should be playing – large, like a peacock, sometimes sacrificing his personal performance in order to lay down intent. After a day's play, Cooky, now a commentator, says to me in private, 'I think he's gone too far. It's too attacking.' But there is method in what he is doing. He is showing the way.

We play golf most afternoons after practice. Baz will say, 'Right, we finish at 12pm today because we have a tee time at 2pm.' It's an attitude once unthinkable for an England coach, but I feel like it might be another stroke of genius. No longer are we playing endless cricket for the sake of it, going down wormholes or negative spirals. The focus is on quality not